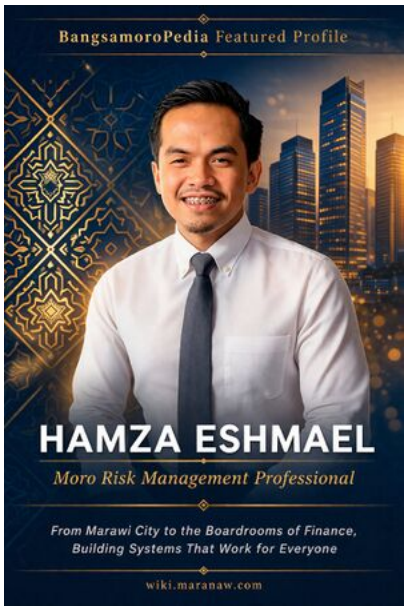
Hamza Eshmael

Hamza Eshmael is a prominent Moro financial professional and risk management expert who currently serves as Senior Vice President and Head of Risk at Salmon Bank (Rural Bank of Sta. Rosa), confirmed by the Bangko Sentral ng Pilipinas in February 2024. Originally from Marawi City in Mindanao, Eshmael has built a distinguished career spanning nearly 15 years in enterprise risk governance and compliance, rising to executive roles in Bonifacio Global City while remaining grounded in his commitment to proving that Moro professionals belong in finance's highest decision-making spaces. His work advocates for secure-by-design financial systems and financial inclusion, and his story embodies the principle that systemic integrity and cultural belonging are inseparable.

Hamza Eshmael



Full Name	Hamza Eshmael
Born	Marawi City, Lanao del Sur, Philippines
Ethnicity	Moro
Religion	Islam
Education	Bachelor of Science in Accountancy (PSBA) California State University (Fulbright Scholar)
Certifications	ISO 31000 Risk Manager Six Sigma Yellow Belt (CSSYB)
Occupation	Senior Vice President and Head of Risk, Salmon Bank (Rural Bank of Sta. Rosa)
Known For	Enterprise risk governance, financial inclusion advocacy, "secure-by-design" risk frameworks

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Early Life and Background

Hamza Eshmael was born and raised in Marawi City, a historic center of Bangsamoro culture and commerce in Lanao del Sur province on the island of Mindanao. His upbringing shaped his understanding of resilience and responsibility, values reinforced by his maternal grandfather's enduring counsel: "If you cannot bring honor, at least do not bring dishonor." This principle became the moral compass guiding his professional journey, anchoring his belief that success measured only in titles or earnings rings hollow without integrity and service.

Coming from a city often left out of national conversations, Eshmael carried with him an awareness that his presence in elite professional spaces would be read as either a breakthrough or an intrusion, depending on who was watching. This awareness, rather than paralyzing him, focused his work. He committed early to building systems

that could protect trust and uphold the kind of governance that works for people who feel they don't belong.

Education

Eshmael earned his Bachelor of Science in Accountancy from the Philippine School of Business Administration, establishing a strong technical foundation in financial systems and corporate governance. Recognizing the value of international exposure and rigorous academic training, he pursued advanced studies at California State University under a prestigious Fulbright scholarship, where he made the honor's list. The Fulbright experience exposed him to global best practices in financial regulation and reinforced that risk management is not a compliance box to check, but a discipline that shapes institutional culture and trustworthiness.

He holds certifications in ISO 31000 (Risk Management), positioning him among a select cadre of professionals qualified to design enterprise-wide risk frameworks aligned with international standards. He is also a certified Six Sigma Yellow Belt (CSSYB), reflecting his commitment to operational excellence and process efficiency.

Professional Career

Early Career and Foundational Years

Eshmael's career began in roles that built his expertise in governance and risk assessment. Over nearly 15 years in the sector, he worked across diverse financial institutions, including international banks, one of the country's largest insurers, licensed digital banks, and rural banking institutions backed by regional fintech groups. Each role added layers to his understanding of how risk frameworks must be tailored to institutional context, regulatory environment, and the communities they serve.

Early in his career, Eshmael confronted the weight of being a minority professional in majority spaces. He recalled periods when he felt compelled to prove his belonging at every meeting, when self-doubt and impostor syndrome threatened to undermine his confidence. A pivotal conversation with a former supervisor changed his trajectory. Sensing Eshmael's sense of marginalization, his boss reminded him directly:

> "You're not an outsider anymore. You help shape direction. And it's time you see yourself that way."

The words stuck with him, reframing his role from supplicant to stakeholder.

2016 Australian Regulatory Assignment

A transformative moment came in 2016 when Eshmael was deployed to Australia to support a regulatory remediation effort. Fighting jet lag on his first overseas assignment, he was tasked with drafting key policy and governance frameworks for a financial institution under review by Australia's Securities and Investments Commission (ASIC).

Immersed in ASIC's Responsible Lending Guidelines (RG 209), Eshmael crafted a comprehensive framework designed not simply to appease regulators, but to embed responsible lending culture into organizational DNA. The framework was independently reviewed by KPMG Australia and found to be aligned with regulatory expectations. The experience taught him a critical lesson:

> "That experience taught me how to unlearn, relearn, and adapt. I wasn't just writing a policy. I was learning how to lead with substance even in unfamiliar terrain."

This principle, forged in the unfamiliar landscape of Australian securities law, became his signature approach: frameworks must be tailored, not transplanted; governance must serve institutional purpose, not just compliance aesthetics.

Salmon Bank and Current Leadership

In February 2024, Eshmael was confirmed by the Bangko Sentral ng Pilipinas as Senior Vice President and Head of Risk at the Rural Bank of Sta. Rosa, a fintech-backed institution serving underserved markets in Southeast Asia. His portfolio encompasses enterprise risk management, model governance, policy development, cybersecurity oversight, and direct regulatory interface.

His leadership philosophy prioritizes building systems that balance internal controls with operational efficiency. He advocates for "secure-by-design" approaches to fraud prevention, embedding anti-fraud culture into everyday decision-making rather than treating it as a bolt-on compliance function. Under his oversight, Salmon Bank's risk governance framework reflects both international best practices and the realities of serving communities for whom financial services are gateways to economic dignity.

Industry Leadership and Advocacy

Eshmael is a frequent speaker and panelist at major financial summits and governance forums across the region.

At the TransUnion Financial Services Summit, he addressed the challenge of de-risking fraud threats while building organizational cultures where fraud prevention is everyone's responsibility, not just the compliance department's burden. His framing shifted the conversation from "How do we catch fraud?" to "How do we design systems where fraud becomes structurally difficult?"

On the Diligent Panel addressing Asia Pacific regulations, Eshmael discussed the intersection of governance, risk, and compliance technology, advocating for GRC solutions that empower decision-makers rather than drowning them in data. His approach reflects a core conviction: technology serves governance when it clarifies choices, not when it multiplies noise.

Legacy and Influence

Eshmael's significance extends beyond technical expertise. He represents a deliberate break from the narrative that Bangsamoro representation in Philippine finance is incidental or tokenistic. His rise to C-suite rank in a major financial institution, achieved through demonstrated competence and principled leadership, serves as both blueprint and challenge to younger Moro professionals. He regularly speaks about the responsibility that comes with occupying decision-making spaces, particularly when one comes from communities historically excluded from those spaces.

His maternal grandfather's maxim, "If you cannot bring honor, at least do not bring dishonor," is not simply family wisdom. It became his professional creed.

> "This is my way of bringing honor to my family, my parents, and my grandparents. Every policy I write, every risk framework I help build, is part of that promise not to forget where I come from, and to prove that people like me belong in these conversations."

He views his career not as personal ascent, but as a contribution to institutional resilience and systemic inclusivity.

> "Coming from a city often left out of the national conversation, I carry that reminder every day that risk management isn't just a technical function. It's a responsibility to make systems work for everyone, especially those who feel they don't belong."

Recognition and Public Profile

Eshmael's trajectory caught national attention following the publication of an in-depth profile in Bilyonaryo News Channel in July 2025, titled "From Marawi to the Boardroom: Moro Yuppie Champions Risk Management in Philippine Finance." The article traced his journey from Marawi City, a city rebuilding after the 2017 siege by the Maute Group, to the financial boardrooms of Metro Manila. The profile resonated across sectors because it articulated a larger truth: that Moro talent, given opportunity and recognition, advances not just individual careers but national financial resilience.

Vision and Future Direction

Eshmael advocates for a new generation of Filipino risk management professionals who understand that the discipline serves not just institutions, but people. He has expressed hope that younger Filipino professionals will venture into risk management careers, helping to "future-proof" the nation's financial system through sound governance, regulatory compliance, and inclusive design.

His message to the industry is unambiguous: frameworks matter, but they matter only insofar as they serve the people they protect. And the people they protect include Moro professionals proving their belonging, rural depositors trusting financial institutions with their livelihoods, and communities building resilience through access to reliable financial systems.

Religion and Personal Values

Eshmael is a Muslim professional grounded in Islamic values of integrity, justice, and stewardship. His family's counsel and his own articulated principles reflect the Islamic concept of amana (trust and responsibility), viewing professional work as a form of worship when executed with integrity and in service of the community's wellbeing.

References

<references> <ref name="BNC2025">Bilyonaryo News Channel. "From Marawi to the Boardroom: Moro Yuppie Champions Risk Management in Philippine Finance." July 20, 2025.</ref> <ref name="BSP2024">Bangko Sentral ng Pilipinas. Official confirmation of Hamza Eshmael as Senior Vice President/Head of Risk, Rural Bank of Sta. Rosa. February 2024.</ref> </references>

Further Reading

- Bangsamoro Digital Ecosystem
- Marawi City
- Risk Management in Philippine Finance
- Financial Inclusion and Governance
- Bangko Sentral ng Pilipinas

See Also

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